

Getting up close

For African meerkats, keeping in touch is an essential part of life. Meerkats live in groups, or packs, in southern Africa's dry, sandy plains. They huddle together in the early morning sunshine to groom and to build social bonds, and they spend the nights close up, in burrows underground. When the adults go out hunting, helpful "aunts" look after the young that are left behind.



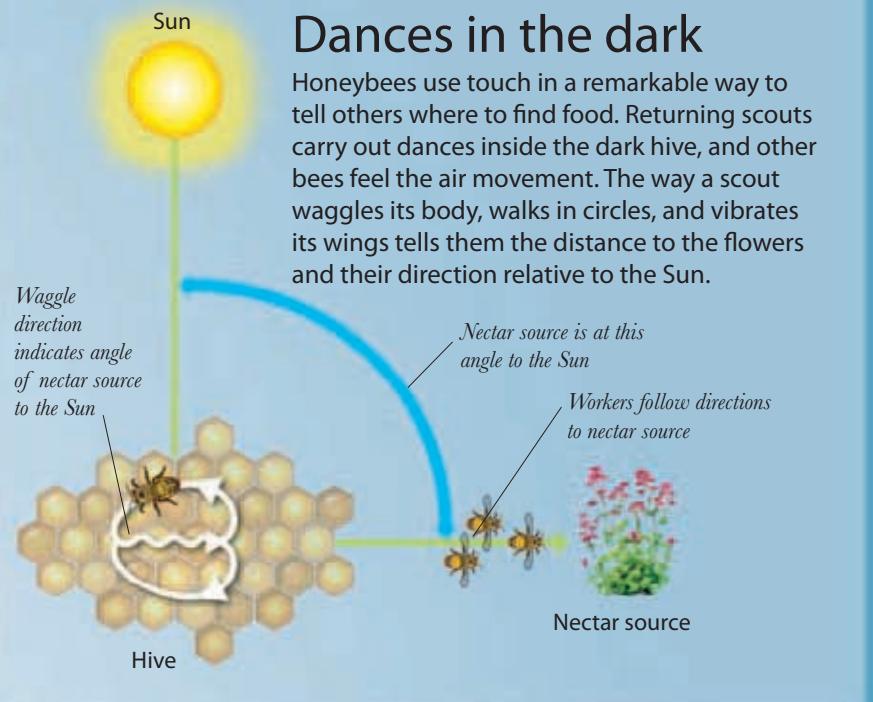
Head-to-head meeting

When two ants meet, they often touch each other with their antennae and their mouths. The contact lasts for just a split second, but it is long enough for them to exchange food and pheromones.

A single worker may meet other ants thousands of times a day, so this communication system can quickly spread signals—and food—throughout the nest.

Dances in the dark

Honeybees use touch in a remarkable way to tell others where to find food. Returning scouts carry out dances inside the dark hive, and other bees feel the air movement. The way a scout waggles its body, walks in circles, and vibrates its wings tells them the distance to the flowers and their direction relative to the Sun.



Teaming up

Sometimes, animals from different species communicate so that they can work together as a team. The watchman goby shares a burrow excavated by the pistol shrimp. If danger threatens, the goby warns the nearly blind shrimp by touching it with its tail, and the two retreat into their shared home.



Shrimp uses antenna to communicate by touch with goby